

COMING TO AMERICA

a novel / screenplay hybrid

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*for anyone already here
still trying to arrive*

1. Day Twelve

FADE IN:

INT. KITCHEN — SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA — DAY

A yellow notice on the fridge. The kind of yellow that does not negotiate.

I touched it first. Of course I did. Someone always has to touch the bomb.

NOTICE TO TERMINATE TENANCY.

Twelve days.

Not twelve years. Not twelve options. Twelve days, written like a parking ticket for a life.

My mother stood with her hands in the dishwater like the dishes were a rosary. My sister refreshed a YouTube video titled something like *TENANT RIGHTS THEY DON'T WANT YOU TO KNOW* at 1.5x speed, which is how modern faith works.

"We have rights," my sister said.

"We have twelve days," I said.

"Gary."

"I'm just saying. Rights require paper. Days require a calendar. We are currently losing at both."

Mom shut off the water.

"There's a path," she said. "We just can't see it yet."

That sentence is my childhood in eight words. I love her. I also wanted to put the sentence in a contractor bag and take it to the curb.

CUT TO BLACK.

My name is Gary. I am forty. I am a heart attack survivor, a sarcastic pain in the ass, and the family appliance that beeps when the house is on fire. People find the beeping

annoying. People also prefer not to burn.

This is the story of twelve days, a missing lease, a garage full of selves, and the stupid, sacred American joke of searching for a country you already live in.

Title card, if this were a movie:

COMING TO AMERICA

Irony intentional.

Do not refund.

2. The Operating Systems

We are not villains.

We are scared humans with incompatible software.

MOM runs on Signs. She believes the correct path will reveal itself if you do not force the universe like a stuck jar. Faith, to her, is a form of patience with better lighting. Deadlines offend her theologically. She will love you through a hurricane and still ask if you packed a sweater.

MY SISTER runs on Precedent and Sentiment. She watches legal explainers until midnight and then cannot throw away a broken chair because the chair "might matter." Time, she has informed me more than once, is a social construct. The landlord's notice, unfortunately, did not get the memo.

ME — Gary — run on Storm Radar. I see weather before the sky admits it. Heart attack will do that. So will years of luxury followed by years of scramble followed by the educational discovery that money is not peace and hardship is not wisdom. What I want now is margin. Margin is wealth. Room to cook. Room to make things. Bills that do not require a subplot. A nervous system that is not always on the night shift.

The problem:

My radar is useful.

My volume is a war crime.

I say *twelve days* and everyone hears *Gary is yelling again*.

I am yelling again.

I am also correct, which makes it worse.

Sometimes the person hardest to live with is carrying the suitcase nobody else wants to claim at baggage claim.

I am not a victim.

I am not a hero.

I am a flawed man trying to protect people who experience my protection as weather.

3. Schrödinger's Box of Envelopes

We cannot find the original lease.

Not me.

Not Mom.

Not my sister.

Not the landlord's people, who speak in the calm voice of someone already packing you into a spreadsheet.

The lease becomes the holy object. Proof. Paper that might mean just-cause, relocation money, time, dignity, a legal spell against Arizona estates and yellow ink.

We search.

Closets. Filing cabinets. The drawer of rubber bands and expired warranties. Boxes labeled IMPORTANT containing a Thai menu from a restaurant that closed during a different presidency. The piano bench. Behind the water heater. Under the bed where dust goes to become ancestry.

"It's like Schrödinger's box of envelopes," I said, because when I am terrified I teach.

Mom blinked. "Whose box?"

I explained — badly — the cat, the box, the quantum joke: until you look, the thing is both there and not there.

Mom thought about this with genuine care.

"Does the cat have oxygen in the box?" she asked.

"That's not the point, Mom!"

"It is if you're the cat."

My sister, without looking up from her phone: "The lease both exists and does not exist until we open the correct box. Gary's right. Also Mom's right. Also we should check the

hall closet again."

So we lived inside the joke.

The lease existed until proven otherwise.

The future existed until discovered.

All of us were cats. All of us were boxes. Oxygen optional.

4. Day Eleven — The Garage Door

INT. GARAGE — NIGHT

Fluorescent light. Seventeen years of inventory staring back like a jury of unfinished selves.

I waited until late to open it. Not lazy. Superstitious. Packing is a confession. You put a life in bags and you are saying the chapter ends whether you are emotionally caught up or not.

The door went up.

The past exhaled.

Lawnmower. Dead treadmill. Keyboard still in a box. Childhood bin. Tools that could fix anything except the deadline. A mountain of optimism purchased on better Tuesdays.

I said, to no one:

"Okay. Let's edit."

4B. Day Eleven Morning — Calendar vs Candle

I printed a calendar and taped it to the fridge next to the yellow notice. Crossed off Day Twelve with a Sharpie like a man keeping score with death.

Mom put a candle next to the calendar.

"Those two things are not friends," I said.

"They're roommates," she said. "Like us."

My sister added a sticky note to the calendar: *CALL LEGAL AID*, and another sticky note to the candle: *also okay*.

This is how we govern: overlapping sticky notes until the fridge looks like a conspiracy board about love.

I made coffee too strong and drank it too fast and felt my heart notice — not panic, just attendance — and I breathed the way the nurse taught me, in through the nose like I was stealing something quiet.

Twelve days.

Eleven now.

The math does not care about candles.

The candles do not care about math.

I live between them. Rent due in both currencies.

5. Contractor Bags

First lesson of the apocalypse:

Regular trash bags are for regular trash.

Seventeen years is not regular.

I bought the thick ones. Contractor bags. Black, industrial, built for demolition and divorce and the end of eras. The cashier asked if I was doing a project.

"Yeah," I said. "Identity."

She waited for the rest of the joke.

There was no rest of the joke.

Cut to montage, if you want the movie version:

MONTAGE — CONTRACTOR BAGS:

-- Gary shakes open a bag like a parachute.

-- A broken lamp goes in.

-- A bread machine goes in.

-- A yoga mat still in plastic goes in. Gary salutes it. "Namaste, never."

-- The bag stands upright, almost proud. It can hold what the thin bags could not: the weight of almos.

END MONTAGE.

The contractor bags were not just for trash.

They were for the parts of me I was finally willing to release without a eulogy committee.

6. Kindergarten

I found something from kindergarten.

A clay lump painted blue, hard as a verdict, with my name carved in the bottom by a teacher who believed in permanence. I held it and — three seconds, no dissolve, just a hard cut in the skull —

FLASH — YOUNG GARY, 5, at a tiny table, telling the future it can sit wherever it wants.

Back to the garage. Fluorescent buzz. Forty-year-old hands.

"I'm forty," I said.

And I threw it away.

Not because the kid was wrong.

Because the kid had been right long enough, and the bag could hold him for a while without me carrying the whole museum on my spine.

My sister later fished it out.

Of course she did.

6B. Lawn Mower Funeral

The lawn mower had not started since a year that still believed in weekends. I dragged it to the curb with the ceremony of a small-town parade.

A man in a paint-stained shirt stopped his truck.

"You throwing that away?"

"I'm releasing it."

"Does it run?"

"It runs on nostalgia. Nostalgia is dry."

He took it anyway. Americans will adopt any machine that might become useful after a sermon and a screwdriver. I watched him load my unfinished yard-person self into his truck and felt jealousy and relief shake hands.

Back in the garage, the empty rectangle where the mower lived looked like a grave and a parking space. Progress often looks like both.

7. The Broken Chair Wars

EXT. BACKYARD — DAY

I moved the broken chair outside. Also: a side table with a wobble like a politician, a box of cables for extinct devices, a suitcase that smelled like 2009.

INT. GARAGE — LATER

They were back.

All of them.

In approximately the same footprints, like I had hallucinated progress.

My sister stood there with dust on her hands and righteousness in her posture.

GARY

Why did you put this back?

SISTER

Because it might matter.

GARY

It's a broken chair.

SISTER

It's *our* broken chair.

Beat.

Neither of us wrong.

That was the insult of it.

I was trying to save the future.

She was trying to protect the past.

The chair was Switzerland and also garbage.

"If it comes with us," I said, "it comes as firewood energy. Metaphorical. Do not light the U-Haul."

She put a hand on the chair like it had a pulse.

"Gary. You throw everything away when you're scared."

"And you keep everything when you're scared. Congrats. We're a complete ecosystem."

She almost smiled. Then she brought the cables back in too, because love is consistent.

I did the double work.

I cursed.

I kept going.

Fear creates movement in me.

Sentiment creates drag in her.

Together we are a machine that almost functions.

8. Day Ten — Mom and the Sign

Mom found a feather on the porch and held it up like evidence.

"See?"

"That is a bird's leftover," I said.

"It's a sign we're not alone."

"We are alone with a yellow paper and eleven days."

"Twelve counting today if you're generous."

"I am not generous with calendars, Mom. Calendars do not tip."

She sat me down like I was twelve, which in her kitchen I still am.

"You see storms," she said gently. "I know. You've always seen storms. After your heart—" She stopped, restarted. "I don't ignore the storms, Gary. I just don't let them be the only weather."

My chest did the old familiar clench — not attack, just memory of attack, the body filing a report.

"If we wait for a sign," I said, "the sign will be a locksmith."

"Maybe the sign is you packing," she said. "Maybe that's God using your anxiety because you won't sit still long enough for a burning bush."

I hated how good that was.

I went to the garage and threw away a dead leaf blower with religious feeling.

9. Both Americas

People want you in one story: spoiled or crushed.

I have been both under one roof.

There was a stretch when money arrived like weather — contract work, dinners with reservations, tipping like morality was a performance. I mistook comfort for character. Then the work dried up the California way: gradually, then all at once, then with experts explaining why nobody could have predicted it.

I learned payment plans.

I learned which bills wait and which bills hunt you.

I learned hardship does not automatically make you wise. It makes you tired with better metaphors.

Luxury did not give me peace.

Struggle did not give me purity.

What I want now:

Margin.

Not a yacht.

Oxygen.

A home that feels like sanctuary instead of countdown.

Creativity that is not squeezed between emergencies like contraband.

Cooking without racing the day.

Music without performing taste for an imaginary panel.

Space to exist without constantly reacting.

After the heart attack, doctors used words like *stress* and *lifestyle* and *lucky*. Lucky is a word that follows you around like a bill collector for gratitude. I am grateful. I am also unfinished. Those can sit in the same box. Oxygen included.

9B. What the Heart Remembers

I do not do the hospital story as a party trick.

People ask. People mean well. People want the scene with the chest pressure and the fluorescent honesty and the moment you bargain with a God you only call when the body files a grievance. I give them the short version: it happened; I lived; I came home different; the different includes weather radar that will not power down.

What I do not always say:

The heart attack taught me that my body believed the storms before my mouth did. Years of performing fine — luxury fine, scramble fine, funny fine — and the meat of me finally called a meeting without me on the invite list.

Survival mode kept me alive.

Survival mode also kept me loud.

The people I love got the siren more than the hug.

This twelve-day circus is not separate from that education. It is the exam. Can I move a life without becoming only the alarm?

Short answer: not perfectly.

Long answer: the pasta still got made. The bags still got filled. I still said sorry for the trumpet. That has to count as coursework.

10. Day Nine — YouTube Law

My sister had a binder.

A literal binder. Tabs. Printouts. Highlighted statutes. Sticky notes that said things like ASK ABOUT RELOCATION and CHECK LOCAL ORDINANCE.

"Time is a social construct," she said, "but this PDF is not."

I loved her so much I wanted to scream.

"Does the PDF stop the notice?" I asked.

"It strengthens our position."

"Our position is a garage."

"Gary."

We called a hotline. We called a friend of a friend. We got soft maybes wrapped in *it depends*. California tenant law is a cathedral designed by twelve architects who never met. The lease — Schrödinger's lease — remained the missing relic.

At midnight she was still watching videos.

I was still packing bags.

Mom was still waiting for a path that felt like peace instead of panic.

Three strategies.

One deadline.

No villain.

Just the American specialty: uncertainty with excellent production design.

11. Three-Second Museum

MONTAGE — OBJECTS / FLASHES:

A softball trophy from a company that laid people off the next week.

FLASH: beer, sun, temporary belonging.

Gary: "Participation. American for *noticed briefly*."

INTO BAG.

A suit from an interview for a job at a company that no longer exists.

FLASH: handshake practice in a bathroom mirror.

Gary keeps the jacket, not the pants. PENDING nail on the wall.

A notebook: START ANYWAY — 2016.

FLASH: younger Gary underlining like the future takes requests.

Gary keeps two notebooks. Recycles the rest. Editing, not betrayal.

Dad's boat magazines — the ones he collected instead of boats.

FLASH: recliner, open water on paper, landlocked dream.

Mom nods once. Gary keeps July 2004. The rest become pulp and permission.

END MONTAGE.

Every object was a version.

The garage was not storage.

It was an anthology.

11B. Day Eight Morning — How Gary Loves

For the record, since the trumpet gets better press:

I love them by doing.

Full tank in Mom's car before she asks. Prescription pickup. The weird lightbulb size. Screenshotting rental listings at 1 a.m. with square footage and gut-feel ratings. A column in my notes app called PEOPLE SURVIVE THIS that is just links to ordinary families who moved and did not dissolve.

My sister loves by remembering.

Mom loves by believing.

I love by pre-grieving the disaster and building a bridge out of contractor bags.

None of these languages are wrong.

All of them sound like nagging when translated under stress.

If you want the soft Gary, catch me when the bag is tied and the label is straight and the storm is briefly quiet. I exist. I am just behind the logistics.

12. Day Eight — Volume

I lost it over tape.

Not metaphorically. We were out of packing tape and my sister said "tomorrow" and tomorrow is a country I do not trust, and my voice climbed into the register that makes everyone go still like prey.

"There is no tomorrow inventory!" I heard myself say. "There is tonight and there is the curb!"

Silence.

Mom's hurt face.

Sister's jaw.

Then my sister, quiet: "We're scared too, Gary. We just don't do it in trumpet."

I went outside and sat on the broken chair I had failed to exile and put my head in my hands until the hypervigilance drained enough to leave a person behind.

This is the uncomfortable truth the story keeps poking:

My fear creates movement.

My urgency forces action.

My PTSD makes me early to the fire and late to the conversation.

They find me exhausting.

Without me, the contractor bags stay in the trunk of the car and the garage stays a museum until the locksmith arrives.

I texted the group chat:

sorry for the trumpet

Sister: *buy tape. then come eat. we made pasta.*

Mom: *I lit a candle. Not instead of tape. In addition.*

We are ridiculous.

We are trying.

13. Day Seven — Half the House

INT. HALLWAY — DAY

Boxes like a skyline. The house already sounding emptier, which is a sound like honesty.

I carried until my back filed a complaint with the union of the body. Heart-aware, always — the little internal project manager asking *is this the good pain or the plot twist pain?* Good pain. Keep moving.

Neighbor Monica brought pizza and the question: "Where will you go?"

"Somewhere with less rent and more stars," I said.

She nodded as if I had said Pasadena.

After she left, Mom whispered, "She's worried for us."

"Everyone's worried for us," I said. "Worry is free. U-Hauls are not."

14. The Location Without the Feeling

EXT. SUBURBAN STREET — GOLDEN HOUR

I walked the block to quiet my nervous system, which is like asking a smoke alarm to do yoga.

Stucco repeating until the eye surrenders. Houses priced like divine apology. Perfect lawns. Empty porches. A Tesla wave that means *thoughts and prayers*. Millions of dollars of property, and somehow the isolation still dense enough to chew.

How can a place this successful feel so impossible?

That question is the engine under the title.

People dream of moving *here*.

I was dreaming of surviving my way *out* — not out of America. Out of the exhibit. Toward a version where the promise is not a view you cannot afford to feel.

Coming to America.

Already here.

Still trying to arrive.

14B. Day Seven and a Half — Inventory of Arguments

We had the same fight in three costumes.

Costume one: the ladle.

Costume two: whether to tell Monica the truth or the Pasadena version.

Costume three: whether packing the photo albums before the kitchen was "out of order" — Mom's phrase, as if grief had a flowchart.

Under every costume: control versus trust versus precedent.

I wrote on a contractor bag with Sharpie, because I am subtle:

GARY: DEADLINE

MOM: SIGN

SISTER: BINDER

Then underneath:

ALSO: LOVE

ALSO: FEAR

ALSO: THE CAT MAYBE HAS OXYGEN

My sister photographed the bag before I filled it. "For the documentary," she said.

"What documentary?"

"The one where we survive you."

Fair.

15. Dream: Margin

DREAM SEQUENCE — DESATURATED SOCAL FALLS AWAY:

Highway. Mountains. High desert opening its hands.

A smaller home. No apology for small.

A workshop: bench, radio, unfinished projects allowed to stay unfinished without becoming moral failure.

Kitchen: garlic, sauce, music that is not content.

Night: stars with no cover charge.

Gary outside with coffee that tastes like coffee, not lifestyle.

For once, no emergency has the microphone.

END DREAM SEQUENCE.

INT. GARAGE — NIGHT

Packing tape stuck to my sleeve.

Leaf blower somewhere on the next block.

The dream does not load the truck.

I do.

16. Day Six — Schrödinger Update

Still no lease.

Mom: "Maybe the sign is that we don't find it."

Me: "That is not a sign. That is a missing document."

Sister: "I'm calling another clinic tomorrow. Legal clinic. Not medical."

Me: "Thank you for clarifying. My heart rate thanked you less."

We laughed. Brief. Real. Did not extend the deadline. Did not need to.

I told Mom again about the cat, because we were tired enough for philosophy.

"If the lease is the cat," she said, "maybe we stop opening every box like the cat needs us to panic. Maybe we pack, and we pray, and we let the box be a box."

"Does the cat have oxygen?" I asked.

She pointed at me. "Now you're learning."

17. Day Five — Sister Yields One Chair

She met me in the backyard with the broken chair and a truce face.

"Keep the photo albums. Keep Dad's one magazine. Keep the good ladle. The chair..."
She exhaled. "The chair can go. But I get to say goodbye."

She sat in it.

It groaned.

She patted the arm.

"You held a lot of arguments," she told the chair. "Rest."

INTO THE CONTRACTOR BAG.

I did not mock her.

Mocking would have been cheaper than love.

"Thank you," I said.

"If you throw away the ladle, I convert to full villain."

"Understood."

18. Day Four — Body Remembers

I got dizzy carrying a dresser.

Sat down hard on the curb. Sister already beside me with water, Mom with the look from the hospital year. The year we do not use as a weapon and also never fully put down.

"I'm okay," I said. "It's just... volume. Of life. Of furniture. Of being forty with a receipt."

"We hire the kids down the street for the heavy stuff," Mom said. Not a question.

I wanted to refuse on principle.

Principle is how I got a heart attack adjacent lifestyle.

I said okay.

Hypervigilance wants to do everything alone because help arrives late in the movies of my nervous system.

Sometimes help arrives with Gatorade and teenagers who need cash.

Let it.

18B. Day Three Point Five — The Landlord's Silence

We left another message.

The estate left another pause.

Silence is also an operating system. Silence runs on *already decided*.

My sister refreshed her inbox like a slot machine.

Mom folded a towel that did not need folding.

I labeled boxes with increasingly unhinged Sharpie energy: KITCHEN (REAL), KITCHEN (EMOTIONAL), DO NOT OPEN — SNAKES (there were no snakes; there was anxiety).

"Gary," Mom said, reading a box. "There are no snakes."

"Correct. That's the comfort."

19. Day Three — Coming to America

INT. U-HAUL CAB — DAWN

Before I turned the key, I put on the exact song.

Neil Diamond.

Coming to America.

Phone to aux. Volume until the speakers fuzzed. No shuffle. That track. On purpose. A dare at my own life.

Brass and promise filled the cab — the myth of arrival — while I sat in a truck full of edited years, already American, leaving the coastal exhibit for a cheaper shot at the feeling.

MONTAGE — COMING TO AMERICA (IRONIC ARRIVAL):

- Stucco developments repeating, beige then braver beige.
- Traffic as nervous system; silent fight in a Lexus, windows up.
- Beautiful neighborhoods, empty sidewalks, belonging with a cover charge.
- Gary's face: sarcastic, wet-eyed, ridiculous.
- Boxes keep 4/4 time in the back.
- City thins. Billboards get lonely. Mountains become geology.
- Desert opens its hands. Sky with room in it.
- Contractor bags in the rearview like blunt little coffins for old selves.
- The song working him over. Patriotic. Satirical. Both.

-- Text on screen, optional, only if you must: COMING TO AMERICA / FROM AMERICA

END MONTAGE.

I voice-texted my sister at a red light:

moving to coming to america by neil diamond. the actual song. on purpose. do not judge me

She sent a flag emoji and a middle finger emoji.

Correct bilingual response.

I hit repeat.

Immigrant to my own nation.

Looking for the version where peace is not a luxury brand.

20. Day Two — Almost

A legal clinic woman with kind eyes and a tired pen said: without the original agreement, leverage was mostly courtesy and timing. We could ask. We could negotiate days. We should not bank the future on a ghost document.

Mom cried once, briefly, then wiped the table as if tears were crumbs.

Sister closed the binder with a sound like a gavel made of paper.

Me: I bought more contractor bags, because endings are thirsty.

Paul-from-the-estate offered "a few extra days as a courtesy."

Courtesy is power holding the door one extra second for credit.

We took it.

We did not send a thank-you note.

21. Day One — What We Carry

INT. EMPTYISH HOUSE — NIGHT

We never found the lease.

Say it plain.

Schrödinger's cat, when the box finally stayed open long enough, was paperwork-shaped air.

Mom lit her candle anyway.

Sister kept the binder anyway — precedent for the next fire.

I stood in the garage doorway looking at the oil stain continent and the nail where PENDING used to live.

The leather jacket came.

Two notebooks came.

The good ladle came.

July 2004 boat magazine came.

The kindergarten clay stayed in the trash, then got rescued by my sister, then got gently re-trashed by both of us together at 11 p.m. like a ritual.

"I'm forty," she said, testing the line.

"Join the club," I said. "Dues are back pain."

We were not ready.

We went anyway.

Readiness is a luxury belief.

Motion is what we had.

21B. What Margin Is (A Working Definition)

Margin is not vacation.

Margin is not winning the lottery and buying a personality.

Margin is:

The water heater breaks and it is a problem, not a plot twist.

You cook on a Tuesday because you want to, not because takeout would break the week.

You leave a song unfinished overnight and trust morning-you to still care.

You hear a weird body sensation and you call the nurse line without also rewriting your will in your head in iambic panic.

You sit in a chair — unbroken — and your brain is not simultaneously packing an invisible go-bag.

I did not have margin in the stucco years, even when I had money.

I am hunting margin inland like other people hunt status.

If that is unserious, fine.

My heart is a very serious literary critic and it gave the stucco years one star.

22. The Move (Imperfect)

Loading was slapstick tragedy.

Mattress won a fight with my shoulder.

Box labeled FRAGILE held sweatshirts.

Box labeled MISC held the will to continue.

The house looked stunned empty.

I thanked it anyway — embarrassing, necessary.

Final walkthrough:

Burn mark on the counter.

Bright rectangle on the fridge where the yellow notice lived.

Key under the mat for the cleaner.

Absurdity of locking a place already becoming someone else's investment.

Mom drove plants.

Sister drove silence (her love language under stress).

I drove the truck and, yes, *Coming to America* one more time until the myth got tired and let ordinary road noise win.

We did not arrive in paradise.

We arrived in a smaller rental with a crooked shed and a landlord named Deb who said, "I don't do drama. I do receipts."

I loved Deb immediately in a practical way.

23. Without Certainty

Here is what did not happen:

No perfect lease reveal in the last box.

No Speedy Gonzales legal miracle.

No cinematic apology from the estate.

No sudden wealth.

No personality transplant making me easy to live with.

Here is what did:

We moved forward anyway.

I watched myself do it — the radar still on, the volume lower by half a notch, the family still here, still incompatible, still mine.

Beginning Gary believed: *If I don't control everything, everything falls apart.*

Ending Gary — provisional, human, still under warranty — understands: *I can move forward even without certainty.* Control was never oxygen. It was just a busier form of drowning.

The storms will still show up on my radar.

I will still annoy people with the weather report.

I will also, maybe, ask if the cat has oxygen before I kick the box.

Growth is annoying.

That is how you know it is not marketing.

24. Enough Room

INT. NEW KITCHEN — NIGHT

Sauce from a jar I improved on principle.

Cheap speaker.

Music walking into rooms before the furniture finishes deciding.

Three plates on a wobbly table leveled with a folded moving receipt — most honest repair I know.

Outside: desert dark, stars, no cover charge.

Inside: Mom humming. Sister assembling a shelf with a level and threats. Me stirring, tasting, existing.

I can hear myself think.

Not as crisis manager.

Not as trumpet.

As a person in a kitchen in a town that does not know my name yet.

The shed waits crooked for a bench.

The bills will still arrive.

My heart will still need sleep and less trumpet.

The missing lease will remain missing — a teacher that never showed and still changed the curriculum.

Margin is not a mansion.

Margin is tonight.

After years of surviving storms, there is enough room — barely, beautifully — to hear myself think.

I put the leather jacket on a hook by the door.

Not PENDING.

Just here.

GARY

(V.O.)

All right. Let's make something here.

FADE OUT.

THE END

25. Epilogue — Later, Not Resolved

Weeks after, the binder still lives on a shelf.

The candle lives in a drawer.

The calendar with the crossed-out days lives in me.

Sometimes I still go trumpet.

Sometimes Mom still waits for a sign that looks like peace instead of a tracking number.

Sometimes my sister still almost rescues trash because the trash has a nickname.

But in the shed there is a bench now.

Crooked shed, honest bench.

Radio with one good station.

A project half-sanded, allowed to stay half.

At night I can hear myself think long enough to finish the thought.

The thought is usually ordinary.

Ordinary is the dream.

FADE OUT FOR REAL THIS TIME.

Bonus Reel: Deleted Texts from the Twelve Days

(found in Gary's phone, never sent, which is how some love stays survivable)

To Mom: *I know you need a sign. What if the sign is the U-Haul reservation email.*

To Sister: *bring back the chair one more time and I will write a folk song about you and it will not be flattering*

To Myself: *volume down. bags up. you are not the only adult in the house. you are just the loudest.*

To the Lease: *exist or don't. we are done letting you be the only story.*

To America: *I'm already here. Meet me halfway on the rent.*

To My Heart: *thank you for the rude meeting. I'm listening. I'm still loud. I'm learning.*